World survey – Iran and South Asia: ancient texts for Hebrew translation

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Prepared 2026-10-21 for `שונות/תרגומי-טקסטים-קדומים/`. Part of the world survey (one file per region).
Region: Avestan (Old and Young), Old Persian, Elamite, Middle Persian/Parthian (only where it preserves old tradition), Vedic and early Sanskrit, Pali/Prakrit, Old Tamil.
Legend: **verified** = fetched today (2026-10-21) from this session and the expected content seen; **reported** = from search results or my own knowledge, not fetched. Bible benefit and Soul benefit are each rated HIGH / MED-HIGH / MEDIUM / LOW.
Downloads made for checking are under `/tmp/claude-0/-home-user-perush/009325a3-391a-55eb-9c0e-32e1e254e6c6/scratchpad/world/iran-india/`. Nothing in `sources/` was touched.

Method note. The session's shared web-search budget (200 calls across all ten agents) ran out after my first ten searches. So the Hebrew-translation records below rest on those searches. Host access, text sizes and licences rest on direct fetches, which were unaffected. Details from my own knowledge are marked "verify" where I am not sure of them. A follow-up session should run the searches named in §4.4.

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0. Key findings

1. **The Rigveda is the best-equipped ancient text in the whole region, perhaps in the whole survey** (verified). The VedaWeb data repository (`raw.githubusercontent.com/VedaWebProject/vedaweb-data`) holds TEI for all ten books. Every stanza comes with:
   - the Zurich morphologically annotated text (lemma, case, number, tense, voice for every word);
   - the van Nooten–Holland metrically restored text, the Lubotsky text, the padapāṭha and Devanāgarī;
   - Geldner's German, Grassmann's German, Griffith's and Macdonell's English and Elizarenkova's Russian;
   - strata labels and the hymn addressees.

   Licences are stated per layer: CC BY 4.0 or CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. Book 10 alone has 191 hymns and 1,754 stanzas (counted). Jamison's full commentary to the Jamison–Brereton translation is free online (updated Sept 2026; verified). Grassmann's *Wörterbuch zum Rig-Veda* and Monier-Williams are open as source files on GitHub (verified). This makes a **"Vedic Genesis" corpus** feasible now: 10.129, 10.90, 10.121, 10.72, 10.190, 1.32 (Indra and the serpent of the waters), 10.10 (Yama and Yamī) and the funeral hymns, together with soul-texts such as the gambler (10.34) and the frogs (7.103).

2. **An Indo-Iranian flood and first-man corpus would mirror the finished Mesopotamian flood corpus directly.** It would take:
   - the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa 1.8.1.1–10 (Manu and the fish; the earliest Indian flood, prose, c. 8th–6th c. BCE);
   - the Mahābhārata 3.185 (54 ślokas, verified count: the fish, the ship with "all the seeds", the Himalaya peak *Naubandhana*, "Ship-Binding");
   - the Vīdēvdād 2 (Yima's *vara*, an enclosure against a deadly winter that keeps the seed of every creature; 43 §§).

   Every text in it is open, short and well preserved. Biblical touch-points: Gen 6:19–7:3 (pairs and seed), 7:16, 8:4 (the mountain), 8:20–21 (Manu's sacrifice after the flood and the birth of Iḍā). It also gives a far-away, three-way control for the Mesopotamian–Genesis relationship.
3. **The Akedah has two strong Vedic counterparts.**
   - The Aitareya Brāhmaṇa 7.13–18 (Śunaḥśepa): a king vows his son to Varuṇa, and a father is hired to bind his own son and raises the knife.
   - The Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa 1.2.3.6–9 (verified text): the gods sacrifice a man, and the sacrificial essence (*medha*) passes from him to the horse, ox, sheep and goat and finally into rice and barley. It is an explicit myth of animal substitution for a human (↔ Gen 22:13, Exod 13:13, 34:20).

   With Kaṭha Upaniṣad 1 (Naciketas, given by his father to Death), these make a small, open, high-value "binding" corpus.
4. **Gen 2:18–24 has a close Indian analogue in Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 1.4.1–4.** The primal Self is alone, afraid and joyless, and "desired a second". It split its own body into husband and wife ("therefore this body is a half"), and the two were united. Gen. Rabbah 8:1 (the *du-parṣufin*) shows the rabbis read Gen 2 the same way. Text: GRETIL (verified). The only Hebrew version is a selection, Fridman 2014.
5. **Iran is less well resourced, but more of it is open than expected.**
   - The Corpus Avesticum Berolinense (CAB, verified) serves a downloadable Avestan corpus (1.3 MB, plain/XML/JSON). Its basis edition covers the whole Yasna, Vīdēvdād 1–22 (except 11), Visperad and the Yašts, with an online edition of **Bartholomae's *Altiranisches Wörterbuch***.
   - A critical edition is finished so far only for Y 35–41 (the Yasna Haptaŋhāiti), Y 47–50, Y 9, Y 52 and Y 54 and Vd 8 (verified from CAB's progress table). For the other Gāthās and most of the Vīdēvdād it is not yet done.
   - TITUS (mirror host `titus.fkidg1.uni-frankfurt.de`, verified) has Geldner's Avesta, the Old Persian corpus, the Indian Bundahišn, the Aitareya Brāhmaṇa and the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa, but forbids republication.
   - Darmesteter (SBE 4, 23), Mills (SBE 31), West (Pahlavi Texts, SBE 5 etc.), Geldner 1886–96 and Bartholomae 1904 are public domain on archive.org (verified items).
6. **The Old Avestan Gāthās (c. 238 stanzas; c. 5,800 words in CAB's corpus without repetitions, counted) and the Yasna Haptaŋhāiti (7 chapters, c. 900 words) are the oldest Iranian texts.** Two passages matter most for the current work on Gen 1:
   - Y 44.3–5, a series of creation questions: "who fashioned light and darkness, sleep and waking, dawn, noon and night?" (↔ Gen 1:3–5, 14–18; Isa 45:7);
   - Y 37.1, a creation list in liturgy: Ahura Mazdā "who created the cow and Truth, the waters and the good plants, the lights and the earth and all good things".

   But the Gāthās are among the most obscure texts on earth: scholarly translations diverge line by line. They suit only a variorum-style translation, with the uncertainty shown.
7. **Law and ritual (commentary priority 4) have the largest number of concrete typological parallels in the region.**
   - Vīdēvdād 5–12 and 16: corpse impurity, contaminated vessels, the nine-night purification with bull's urine, menstruation (↔ Num 19, Lev 11:32–35, 15:19–24). Vd 4 has graded penalties for assault and broken contracts (↔ Exod 21:18–27). Vd 15 covers seduction, pregnancy and abortion (↔ Exod 21:22, 22:15–16).
   - The Dharmasūtras: the five permitted five-nailed animals and the fish rules (↔ Lev 11, Deut 14), birth and death impurity (↔ Lev 12, Num 19), *niyoga* (↔ Deut 25:5–10), the eldest son's extra share (↔ Deut 21:17).
   - The Vedic animal sacrifice: the omentum (*vapā*) is offered first (↔ Lev 3:3–4).
8. **Hebrew translations already exist, but only as selections, without an apparatus and published by commercial houses (copyright).** None was found for any Avestan, Old Persian, Elamite or Pahlavi text.

Translator	Title	Publisher, year	Status
Amram Peter	מזמורים מן הריג-ודה (61 hymns)	Carmel, 2006	—
Tzachi Fridman	האופנישדות והברהמנות	Carmel, 2014	—
Ithamar Theodor	הבהגווד גיטא	Carmel, 2002	—
Asaf Federman	דברי אמת (דהמפדה)	Pardes, 2011	—
David Shulman	דקדוק האהבה: שירה טמילית עתיקה	Carmel; e-vrit lists Feb 2026, an earlier edition c. 2012	verify
Keren Sheffi	Therīgāthā selections	online	—

For details see §2.

9. **Old Tamil Sangam poetry, the Therīgāthā and Aśoka's edicts have little or nothing for the Torah but are first-rate windows on "the soul of the ancients".**
   - The Sangam anthologies: about 2,380 poems, c. 1st–3rd c. CE, in a sophisticated landscape code of love and war.
   - The Therīgāthā: about 73 poems by Buddhist nuns, c. 5th–3rd c. BCE oral; the oldest anthology of women's poetry in India.
   - Aśoka's edicts: the original stones of the 3rd c. BCE, with a king's remorse after the Kalinga war.

   Base texts are open: GRETIL/Project Madurai Kuṟuntokai in ISO romanization (verified), and SuttaCentral Pali with CC0 English (verified).
10. **The later texts that look most "biblical" are the latest.** The Bundahišn's creation in six stages, and its first couple Maši and Mašyānē who are deceived and eat, are redacted in the 9th c. CE, in a Zoroastrianism that lived alongside Judaism, Christianity and Islam. The same holds for the Purāṇic flood and the Bhaviṣya Purāṇa's "Adam and Noah" (a late interpolation). They are worth a flagged entry, never a primary control.
11. **How well an LLM reads each language (my assessment).**

Language	Rating	Notes
Brāhmaṇa and Upaniṣad prose; Classical Sanskrit (epic, Dharmasūtras); Pali	good, low risk	—
Rigvedic Sanskrit	medium risk	many hapaxes and contested words; manageable with VedaWeb morphology, Grassmann, Geldner and Jamison
Old Persian	low–medium risk	small, well-understood corpus
Young Avestan	medium-high risk	formulaic, and Bartholomae is open, but the dictionary is 120 years old
Old Tamil	medium-high risk	—
Pahlavi	high risk	the script is ambiguous; work only from a transcribed edition
Old Avestan	very high risk	—
Elamite	very high risk; poorly understood	—

12. **Access.**
    - Open and working: GRETIL, VedaWeb (site and GitHub raw), CAB, the TITUS mirror, archive.org, ISAC (free OIP PDFs; Hallock's *Persepolis Fortification Tablets* PDF, 58.8 MB), SuttaCentral (API and GitHub raw), DCS, DSAL, Livius, Project Madurai.
    - Not reachable from this session:
      - avesta.org: its TLS certificate has expired;
      - TITUS main host: connection reset;
      - SARIT, gandhari.org, the Avestan Digital Archive (ada.usal.es), Achemenet, Iranica: proxy 502, reset or 403;
      - sacred-texts.com: 403 for sub-pages;
      - the Cologne Sanskrit-lexicon site: 403, but its sources work through GitHub raw;
      - ORACC: TLS chain error, a problem for the Achaemenid inscriptions if a session wants ORACC's ARIo.

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1. Ranked shortlist

#	Text	Language · date (composition / oral) · earliest ms	Size · condition	Bible focus (verses)	Soul focus	Bible / Soul benefit	Base text (open?)	Feasibili
1	**Rigveda: a "Vedic Genesis + soul" selection** (10.129, 10.90, 10.121, 10.72, 10.190, 10.81–82, 1.32, 10.10, 10.14–18, 10.85, 10.125, 10.95, 10.34, 7.103, Uṣas hymns, 10.117)	Vedic · c. 1500–1000 BCE (bk 10 latest), oral, fixed with extreme fidelity · mss c. 11th–15th c. CE (reported)	c. 25 hymns ≈ 300 stanzas (whole RV 1,028 hymns / 10,552 st.) · perfect	Gen 1:1–2 (10.129: darkness, undistinguished water), 1:21 (1.32 serpent of waters), 1:26–27 (10.90 Puruṣa), 2:7, 3:19 (10.18), Gen 4–5 (10.10 sibling incest), Prov 8 (10.125)	prayer, death and burial, marriage, gambling, wit, generosity, doubt (10.129 "perhaps he does not know")	MED-HIGH / HIGH	VedaWeb TEI, CC BY / BY-NC-SA 4.0 (**verified**); GRETIL Aufrecht TEI	HIGH
2	**Indo-Iranian flood corpus**: ŚB 1.8.1.1–10 + MBh 3.185 + Vīdēvdād 2 (Yima's *vara*)	Vedic prose c. 800–600 BCE; epic Skt c. 300 BCE–300 CE; Young Avestan c. 900–400 BCE (oral) · mss: ŚB/MBh 2nd mill. CE; Avesta 1323 CE	10 kaṇḍikās + 54 ślokas + 43 §§ (≈ 2,500 words) · perfect	Gen 6–9 (6:14 ark, 6:19–7:3 seed/pairs, 7:16, 8:4 mountain, 8:20–21 sacrifice), 9:1 repopulation	the lone survivor, the grateful fish, winter as apocalypse, the paradise-enclosure	HIGH / MED-HIGH	GRETIL (**verified** ŚB 1.8.1, MBh 3.185); CAB basis ed. of Vd 2 (**verified**); Darmesteter SBE 4 PD	HIGH (Avestan part MEDIUM)
3	**"Binding" corpus**: Aitareya Br. 7.13–18 (Śunaḥśepa) + ŚB 1.2.3.6–9 (substitution) + Kaṭha Up. 1 (Naciketas)	Vedic prose c. 800–500 BCE (gāthās in AB older) · mss 2nd mill. CE	≈ 120 verses/paragraphs · good	Gen 22 (22:9–13 binding, knife, ram), Exod 13:13, 22:28–29, 34:20 (redemption of firstborn), Judg 11, Lev 27 vows	fathers and sons, vows to gods, a boy's dialogue with Death	HIGH / HIGH	TITUS AB (Aufrecht 1879, PD; **verified**); GRETIL ŚB, Kaṭha (**verified**); Keith 1920 PD	HIGH
4	**Early Upaniṣads: selection** (BAU 1.1–1.4, 1.5, 2.4, 3.6, 4.3–4; CU 1.2, 6, 8.7–12; Kaṭha)	Late Vedic · c. 700–400 BCE oral (Olivelle) · mss 2nd mill. CE	≈ 2,500 lines possible; choose c. 600 · perfect	Gen 2:18–24 (BAU 1.4: alone → split → man and woman), Gen 1:2 (BAU 1.2), Gen 3:22 (immortality), Deut 6:7 (teaching sons)	death, self, love, sleep and dreams, father–son teaching	HIGH (BAU 1.4) / HIGH	GRETIL TEI (**verified**)	HIGH

#	Text	Language · date (composition / oral) · earliest ms	Size · condition	Bible focus (verses)	Soul focus	Bible / Soul benefit	Base text (open?)	Feasibili
5	**Vīdēvdād: selection** (Vd 1, 3, 4, 5–9, 13, 15, 16, 18, 19 + 2 in #2)	Young Avestan, "school" redaction perhaps Achaemenid (debated) · earliest mss 1323 CE (reported)	whole ≈ 26,000 words w/o repetitions (counted); selection ≈ 10,000 · good	Lev 11:32–35, 12, 15:19–24, 18:19; Num 19 (corpse impurity, purification); Exod 21:18–27, 21:22, 22:15–16; Gen 10 (Vd 1 lands); Gen 3 (Vd 19 temptation)	fear of decay and death, dogs, the farmer's righteousness, women's bodies	HIGH (law/ritual) / HIGH	CAB basis ed. (**verified**), TITUS (Geldner); Darmesteter SBE 4 PD (**verified** archive.org)	MEDIUM
6	**Gāthās + Yasna Haptaŋhāiti** (Y 28–34, 43–51, 53; Y 35–41)	Old Avestan · c. 1200–900 BCE (debated: 1500–600), oral · mss 1323 CE	17 hymns, ≈ 238 st. (≈ 5,800 words) + 7 ch. (≈ 900 words) · good text, obscure meaning	Gen 1:3–5, 14–18 (Y 44.3–5), Gen 1 creation list (Y 37.1), Deut 30:15–19 (Y 30 choice), Isa 45:7	the earliest voice of a named prophet: lament, doubt, questions to God (Y 46.1 "To which land shall I flee?")	MED-HIGH / HIGH	CAB (YH critical ed.; Gāthās basis ed.) (**verified**); Geldner PD; Bartholomae PD	LOW–MEDIUM (variorum only)
7	**Atharvaveda: selection** (Śaunaka; Paippalāda for variants): Earth hymn 12.1, love charms, healing (takman, kilāsa), conception, the Brahmacārin, Kāla, funeral book 18	Vedic · c. 1200–900 BCE oral · mss: Paipp. Orissa palm-leaf 16th c.+ (reported)	730 hymns / ≈ 6,000 st.; selection ≈ 60 hymns · good	Num 5 (ordeal/curse waters), Lev 13 (white skin disease), Gen 25:21, 30:14–16 (fertility), Exod 22:17, Deut 18:10–11; Gen 1:11–12, 2:7 (Earth)	everyday fears and desires: love, jealousy, fever, worms, childbirth	MEDIUM / HIGH	GRETIL Śaunaka (Orlandi/Roth–Whitney, accented version also) and Paippalāda TEI (Griffiths, Zehnder, Lubotsky et al., CC BY-NC-SA) (**verified**)	HIGH
8	**Yašts + Hōm Yašt**: Yt 10 (Mithra), 8 (Tištrya), 5 (Anāhitā), 19 (Zamyād: Yima's fall), 13 (Fravardīn: Gaya Marətan), 22 (Hādōxt: the soul after death), Y 9	Young Avestan, old Indo-Iranian myth · oral, c. 900–500 BCE · mss 14th c.+	Yt 10 ≈ 146 st.; selection ≈ 8,000 words · good, some corrupt passages	Gen 1:21 (Aži Dahāka, Gandarəβa of the sea), Gen 3 (Yima's lie and loss of glory), Gen 8:22 / Deut 11:14 (rain-star), covenant (*miθra* = contract ↔ *berit*, Deut 28)	hymns of awe, the star racing the drought-demon, the soul meeting its own conscience as a maiden	MEDIUM / HIGH	CAB (**verified**); Darmesteter SBE 23 PD; Geldner PD	MEDIUM

#	Text	Language · date (composition / oral) · earliest ms	Size · condition	Bible focus (verses)	Soul focus	Bible / Soul benefit	Base text (open?)	Feasibili
9	**Aggañña Sutta (DN 27) + Sutta Nipāta old strata** (Aṭṭhakavagga, Pārāyanavagga, Khaggavisāṇa)	Pali · oral c. 5th–3rd c. BCE; written 1st c. BCE (Sri Lanka) · mss mostly 18th–19th c.	DN 27 ≈ 32 §§; Snp ≈ 1,149 verses (select ≈ 400) · perfect	Gen 2–3 (paradise lost by eating; bodies coarsen, sexes appear, shame), 4:17–22 (houses, fields, theft), 1 Sam 8 (first king elected)	ironic Buddhist answer to Brahmin cosmogony; ascetic poetry	MED-HIGH (DN 27) / HIGH	SuttaCentral bilara-data, root text + Sujato translation **CC0** (**verified**)	HIGH
10	**Dharmasūtras** (Āpastamba, Gautama, Baudhāyana, Vasiṣṭha): selections on purity, food, sacrifice, inheritance, *niyoga*, crime	Sanskrit sūtra · c. 3rd–1st c. BCE (Olivelle) · mss 2nd mill. CE	four texts ≈ 3,500 sūtras; select ≈ 800 · good	Lev 11 / Deut 14 (permitted animals), Lev 12, Num 19, Deut 25:5–10, Deut 21:17, Exod 21–22 (theft, assault), Lev 19	how a Brahmin household lived day by day	HIGH (law) / MEDIUM	GRETIL TEI (**verified**); Bühler SBE 2, 14 PD (**verified**)	HIGH
11	**Śatapatha cosmogonies and sacrifice**: ŚB 6.1.1, 11.1.6, 14.1.2.11 (boar raises earth), 2.2.4, 3.7–3.8 (paśubandha), 11.5.1 (Purūravas–Urvaśī), 1.6.3 (Vṛtra)	Vedic prose c. 800–500 BCE	≈ 300 kaṇḍikās · good (GRETIL has data-entry gaps "...")	Gen 1:2, 1:9 (dry land), Lev 1–7 (omentum ↔ Lev 3:3–4), Gen 1:21	the ritualist's world: sacrifice as cosmos	MED-HIGH / MEDIUM	GRETIL (Mādhyandina; gaps), TITUS (accented), Weber 1855 PD; Eggeling SBE PD (**verified**)	HIGH
12	**Sangam anthologies**: Kuṟuntokai (401) + Puṟanāṉūṟu (400), with Aiṅkuṟunūṟu (500 short poems)	Old Tamil · c. 1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE (core), anthologized c. 5th–8th c. · palm-leaf mss 17th–19th c.; first printed 1887–1915	Kuṟ. 401 poems (4–8 lines); Puṟam 400 · good	Song of Songs (typological); 1 Kgs 10:22 *tukkiyyim* ← Tamil *tōkai* (peacock; debated loan)	love in coded landscapes; war, hero stones, widowhood, the bard's life	LOW / HIGH	GRETIL/Project Madurai romanized (**verified** Kuṟuntokai PM0110); Tamil Lexicon on DSAL (**verified** host)	MEDIUM
13	**Therīgāthā** (+ Theragāthā selection)	Pali · oral c. 5th–3rd c. BCE · written 1st c. BCE	73 poems / ≈ 522 verses; Thag 1,279 v. · perfect	(none direct)	women's voices: liberation from husbands, grief for children, old age (Ambapālī)	LOW / HIGH	SuttaCentral CC0 (**verified**); GRETIL	HIGH

#	Text	Language · date (composition / oral) · earliest ms	Size · condition	Bible focus (verses)	Soul focus	Bible / Soul benefit	Base text (open?)	Feasibili
14	**Aśoka's edicts** (14 Major Rock Edicts, 7 Pillar Edicts, minor edicts; Kandahar Greek–Aramaic)	Prakrit (several dialects), Brahmi/Kharoṣṭhī · 268–232 BCE · **the originals**	≈ 35 inscriptions, ≈ 12,000 words incl. versions (verify) · good	Deut 17:14–20 (the king), Lev 17 / Deut 12:15 (slaughter), Deut 22:6–7, 25:4 (animals)	a king's remorse and moral programme	LOW–MEDIUM / MED-HIGH	Hultzsch 1925 CII I, PD mark on archive.org (**verified**)	MED-HIGH
15	**Mahābhārata selections**: Sāvitrī (3.277–283, 297 śl.), Nala (3.50–78, 901 śl.), Ṛṣyaśṛṅga (3.110–113, 101 śl.), Śibi (3.130–131), Yakṣa questions (3.297–298)	Epic Sanskrit · oral bardic c. 400 BCE–400 CE, redacted · mss 2nd mill. CE (critical ed. BORI 1933–66)	counts verified · perfect	Ṛṣyaśṛṅga ↔ Gilgameš' Enkidu/Šamḫat and Gen 38; Sāvitrī ↔ Song 8:6	love stronger than death; the gambler-king; riddles	LOW–MEDIUM / HIGH	GRETIL (Smith's e-text of the CE; "reference only") (**verified**)	HIGH
16	**Bundahišn** (creation, Gayōmard, Mašī–Mašyānē, the end)	Middle Persian (Pahlavi) · redacted 9th c. CE from the Zand of lost Avestan nasks · mss 14th–16th c. (verify)	≈ 36 ch.; select ≈ 6 · good	Gen 1 (creation in six stages over a year), Gen 2–3 (first couple, lie, eating, clothing), Gen 10	the Zoroastrian cosmic drama	MEDIUM (late!) / MEDIUM	TITUS Indian Bundahišn (**verified** page); West SBE 5 PD; Pakzad 2005 ed. (©)	LOW–MEDIUM
17	**Old Persian royal inscriptions**: DB (Bisitun), DNa, DNb, DSe/DSf, XPh (daiva), XPl	Old Persian (+ Elamite, Akkadian, Aramaic versions) · 520–330 BCE · **the originals**	≈ 6,000 words whole corpus (verify) · good	(Torah: Gen 10:2 Madai, 10:22 Elam only); Ezra 1, 6–7; Esther 1:1, 1:19, 8:9–10; Dan 6	royal ideology: Truth vs. the Lie	LOW (Torah) / MEDIUM	TITUS (**verified**); King & Thompson 1907 PD; Livius English (**verified**); Kent 1953 lending-only	HIGH
18	**Middle Persian/Parthian survivals**: Draxt ī Asūrīg (goat vs. palm debate), Ayādgār ī Zarērān, Ardā Wirāz Nāmag	Parthian/MP · oral Parthian (c. 2nd c. BCE–3rd c. CE), written 9th–10th c.	≈ 120 verses / 114 §§ / 101 ch. · fair	Draxt ↔ Sumerian debates (Bird and Fish, done!); AWN ↔ tours of hell	the minstrel's genres	LOW / MEDIUM	West/Haug–Hoshangji PD (AWN 1872); modern eds ©	LOW–MEDIUM
19	**Persepolis Fortification Tablets** (Elamite)	Achaemenid Elamite · 509–493 BCE · **originals**	2,087 texts in Hallock · good	Lev 12:2–5 (birth rations by sex of child, inverse of Lev 12's purity periods; verify Brosius), Num 1 (rations, census)	everyday administration, women workers, travel	LOW / MEDIUM	Hallock 1969 OIP 92 free PDF (**verified**)	LOW

Runners-up: the Rāmāyaṇa (1.2, the *krauñca* bird and the birth of poetry; Ṛṣyaśṛṅga 1.8–10), Manusmṛti 1 (creation; Brahmā split into male and female, 1.32 ↔ Gen 1:27, but c. 2nd c. CE), the Jaina Ācārāṅga I, the Jātaka verses (the Mahosadha "judgment of the child" ↔ 1 Kgs 3), Gṛhyasūtras (life-cycle rites ↔ Lev 12).

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2. The survey

2.1 The Rigveda (selection) — top candidate

Vedic Sanskrit · c. 1500–1000 BCE (family books 2–7 oldest; book 10 and parts of 1 latest, c. 1100–900 BCE), dated by language, the Mitanni Indo-Aryan names (c. 1380 BCE) and the absence of iron · orally fixed with mnemonic checks (padapāṭha and others) that preserved even the accents · earliest manuscripts c. 11th–15th c. CE (the Pune collection is UNESCO Memory of the World, 2007; reported) · 1,028 hymns, 10,552 stanzas (≈ 165,000 words) · preservation: perfect.

- *What it is.* Hymns of priestly poet-families, sung at the soma sacrifice to Agni, Indra, Soma, Varuṇa, Mitra, Uṣas and others. Their hearers met dense riddles, praise in return for cattle and sons, the joy of soma, Indra's killing of the serpent who held back the waters, and the dawn as a beautiful woman. Book 10 adds speculation and life-cycle hymns: wedding, funeral, healing, gambling.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - **Gen 1:1–2.** 10.129 (7 st.): "Neither non-being nor being was then; no air, no sky … what covered it, where, in whose keeping? Was there water, deep, unfathomable? … Darkness was hidden by darkness in the beginning; all this was undistinguished water (*salila*) … That One breathed, windless, by its own power … Who knows whence this creation came? … he who oversees it in the highest heaven, he surely knows – or perhaps he does not know." Darkness, water and breath before differentiation ↔ *ḥošek*, *tehom*, *ruaḥ*. Typological, but an excellent control, because Gen 1 has no "perhaps he does not know".
  - **Gen 1:2, 1:26–27.** 10.121 (10 st.): the Golden Embryo upon the waters; refrain "To which god shall we offer?" ↔ Gen 1:2 *merahefet* (brooding?). 10.90 (16 st.): the cosmic Man, sacrificed and dismembered by the gods, from whose parts come the social classes, sun, moon, sky and earth. It inverts Gen 1:26–27 (man last, in God's image) and is close to Enūma eliš (Tiamat's body), so it gives a three-way comparison. 10.72 and 10.190 (*ṛta* and *satya* from heat; then night, ocean, year; "Dhātṛ fashioned sun and moon as before") ↔ Gen 1:14–18.
  - **Gen 1:21.** 1.32 (15 st.): Indra kills Vṛtra, the serpent (*ahi*) lying on the mountain and enclosing the waters, which then flow like lowing cows ↔ Ps 74:13–14, Isa 27:1, Job 26:12–13. Gen 1:21's demythologized *tanninim* is directly relevant to the fifth-day commentary. See Watkins 1995, *How to Kill a Dragon* (Indo-European dragon-slaying formula). The motif is accepted as a shared ancient type; no contact with Israel.
  - **Gen 4–5.** 10.10 (14 st.): the twins Yamī and Yama, the first humans. She urges him to unite with her for offspring; he refuses ("they call it evil"). ↔ the unspoken question of Cain's wife (Gen 4:17), Gen 19:30–38 ("to preserve seed"), Lev 18:9. 10.14 (Yama, first to die, "found the path for the many") ↔ Gen 5's refrain "and he died".
  - **Gen 3:19.** 10.18.10–13: "Creep to this mother earth … Earth, open up … as a mother covers her son with her hem, cover him" ↔ Gen 3:19 (and Job 1:21).
  - **Prov 8:22–31** (outside the Torah). 10.125 (Vāc, the goddess Speech: "I am the queen … I bend the bow for Rudra") ↔ Lady Wisdom.
  - **Deut 15:7–11.** 10.117 (generosity) ↔ the open hand.
- *Soul of the ancients.* HIGH:
  - 10.34, the gambler's lament: his wife deserts him, his mother-in-law hates him, the dice "burn like coals"; the god's advice: "Don't play with dice; till your field";
  - 7.103, the frogs: Brahmins at the rains-feast, satire or a rain-charm;
  - the Uṣas hymns, 1.113 and 1.48: dawn, ageing, generations;
  - 10.85, the wedding of Sūryā;
  - 10.95, Purūravas and Urvaśī: "there are no friendships with women; their hearts are hyenas'";
  - 10.97, the healing plants;
  - 1.164, the riddle hymn.

- *Base text and tools.*
  - **VedaWeb TEI** (`raw.githubusercontent.com/VedaWebProject/vedaweb-data/main/rigveda/TEI/rv_book_NN.tei`; book 10 = 40 MB; **verified**) has, per stanza:
    - Zurich text with full morphology and Grassmann lemma links;
    - Lubotsky, van Nooten–Holland and Aufrecht texts, padapāṭha, Devanāgarī;
    - translations: Geldner, Grassmann, Griffith, Macdonell, Elizarenkova;
    - strata, metre and addressees.

    Licences per layer CC BY 4.0 / CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 (verified in the TEI header), so the text is committable under the repo's ETCSL precedent.
  - **GRETIL** Aufrecht TEI and padapāṭha (verified in the listing).
  - **Dictionaries:** Grassmann's *Wörterbuch zum Rig-Veda* (1873, PD), with every attestation by stanza (GitHub `sanskrit-lexicon/csl-orig v02/gra/gra.txt`, **verified**); Monier-Williams, Böhtlingk–Roth PW (same repo, verified). Mayrhofer *EWAia* (©).
  - **Grammar and lexicon:** Macdonell, *Vedic Grammar* (1910) and *Vedic Reader* (1917; PD, annotated hymns).
  - **DCS** (Digital Corpus of Sanskrit, morphologically analysed, includes Vedic; site verified).
  - **Translations:**
    - Jamison & Brereton 2014 (OUP, ©), with **Jamison's online commentary, all ten books, updated Sept 2026** (`rigvedacommentary.alc.ucla.edu`, verified; free to read, ©);
    - Geldner 1951 (German; in VedaWeb);
    - Witzel–Gotō 2007 / 2013 (German, books 1–5; ©);
    - Renou, *EVP*;
    - Elizarenkova;
    - Doniger 1981 (Penguin selection; ©);
    - Griffith 1889–92 (PD; dated).
  - **Hebrew:** Amram Peter, *מזמורים מן הריג-ודה* (Carmel 2006; 61 hymns, verse, with introduction and annotated index; ©). Our version would add a word-by-word apparatus and biblical echo control.
- *Feasibility and risks.* Rigvedic Sanskrit is harder than Classical Sanskrit: archaic syntax, deliberately riddling language and many disputed words. But the tooling is the best of any language in this survey. Risk: medium; check every hymn against Geldner and Jamison after drafting.
- *Benefit:* Bible MED-HIGH / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate first**, as a corpus of about 25 hymns arranged as "Beginnings, Waters and Serpent, First Humans, Death, Life".

2.2 The Indo-Iranian flood and its survivor: ŚB 1.8.1 · MBh 3.185 · Vīdēvdād 2

Three texts.

- **ŚB 1.8.1.1–10.** Vedic prose (Mādhyandina), c. 8th–6th c. BCE; 10 kaṇḍikās of a 44-kaṇḍikā brāhmaṇa; perfect.
- **MBh 3.185.** Epic Sanskrit, the *Matsyopākhyāna* told by Mārkaṇḍeya; the text was stable by c. 300 CE, oral older; 54 ślokas (counted); perfect.
- **Vd 2.** Young Avestan, oral, perhaps c. 900–500 BCE; earliest mss 1323 CE; 43 §§, ≈ 1,170 words in CAB without repetitions (counted); good.
- *What it is.*
  - In the ŚB, a small fish comes into Manu's hands with his washing water: "Rear me and I will save you … a flood will carry off all these creatures." Manu raises it in a jar, a trench and then the sea, builds a ship in the year foretold, ties the ship's rope to the fish's horn and is pulled over "this northern mountain". The flood carries off all creatures, "and Manu alone remained here". Wishing for offspring, he offers ghee, sour milk, whey and curds into the waters. A year later a woman, Iḍā, arises, "with ghee in her footprint"; through her he begets this race.
  - The MBh version adds the seven sages and "all the seeds, as I told you before" (3.185.30, verified), and names the peak Naubandhana, "the Ship-Binding" (3.185.47, verified).
  - In Vd 2, Ahura Mazdā offers Yima the religion, and Yima declines to carry it but agrees to rule. Under his reign men, cattle and dogs grow so many that he widens the earth three times. Then Ahura Mazdā warns of evil winters (*mahrkūša*, in later tradition the demon Malkōsān) that will freeze the world. Yima is told to build a *vara*, an enclosure, and to bring into it "the seed of all men and women … of all cattle … of all plants … in pairs, inexhaustible", with light inside that is self-created.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - Gen 6:19–7:3 (pairs and seed; "to keep seed alive", 7:3 ↔ Vd 2.27–28).
  - Gen 6:14–16 (the structure: Yima's *vara* has streets, doors and a window ↔ Gen 6:16 *ṣohar*, door and storeys).
  - Gen 7:23 ("only Noah was left" ↔ "Manu alone remained").
  - Gen 8:4 (the mountain).
  - Gen 8:20–21 (an offering after the flood that produces a new beginning: in the ŚB it literally produces the mother of mankind) and Gen 9:1.

  Consensus: the Mesopotamian origin or influence of the Indian fish-flood is **debated**. Many think it entered India via Mesopotamian contact; others say it is an independent fish-avatar myth. Yima's *vara* as a "Noah" is **debated**: it is a winter catastrophe, not a flood, and closer to an Iranian Golden-Age refuge. Lincoln and others link it to Indo-Iranian Yama myths. For this project the value is in the **deviations**: no divine anger at sin in the ŚB, a fish saviour instead of a god's warning, sacrifice producing a wife, and cold instead of water.

- *Soul of the ancients.* The reciprocity of a small creature saved and saving; the fear of winter on the Iranian plateau; a paradise remembered as a garrison against the world's end.
- *Base text and tools.*
  - ŚB: GRETIL `1_sanskr/1_veda/2_bra/satapath/sb_01_u.htm` (text checked, **verified**; based on the Weber edition, unaccented; GRETIL "reference purposes only"); TITUS ŚB Mādhyandina (accented; verified page; no republication). Weber 1855 is PD (reported). Eggeling SBE 12 (1882) on archive.org (verified).
  - MBh: GRETIL (BORI critical-edition e-text; verified).
  - Vd 2: CAB basis edition (verified); Geldner 1896 PD; Darmesteter SBE 4 (1880/1895) PD (verified archive.org).
  - Dictionaries: Bartholomae (CAB online; 1904 PD on archive.org, verified).
  - Modern translations: Olivelle and others for the ŚB (verify which); Jamison–Brereton notes; Skjærvø's Young Avestan reader includes Vd 2 (reported); Lincoln's studies of Yima (reported).
  - Hebrew: none of these three was found (Fridman 2014 includes Brāhmaṇa selections, possibly the Manu flood; verify).
- *Feasibility.* The Sanskrit is easy prose and simple epic. The Avestan is formulaic but needs Bartholomae and the Pahlavi Zand.
- *Benefit:* Bible HIGH / Soul MED-HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate as one corpus beside `/סיפורי-המבול-המסופוטמיים`**, cross-referenced to its parallels index. The Matsya Purāṇa 1–2 flood (later, Purāṇic) could go in an appendix, flagged.

2.3 The "binding" corpus: Śunaḥśepa, the substitution of the victim, Naciketas

Aitareya Brāhmaṇa 7.13–18: Vedic prose with embedded *gāthās* (older verse), c. 8th–6th c. BCE; recited at the royal consecration (*rājasūya*); also in Śāṅkhāyana Śrautasūtra 15.17–27 (reported). **ŚB 1.2.3.6–9:** 4 kaṇḍikās. **Kaṭha Upaniṣad 1.1–3:** c. 5th–3rd c. BCE (reported). Size ≈ 120 sentences and verses; perfect.

- *What it is.*
  - King Hariścandra, sonless, vows to Varuṇa that if a son is born he will sacrifice him. The son Rohita is born; the king delays ("when he has teeth … when he is armed"), and Rohita flees to the forest for six years. Rohita then buys Śunaḥśepa, the middle son of the starving Brahmin Ajīgarta, for 100 cows. The father takes another 100 to bind him to the post and another 100 to come forward with the knife. The boy praises the gods with Rigvedic verses (RV 1.24–30 tradition), his bonds fall away, and he is adopted by Viśvāmitra. The father's betrayal is condemned.
  - ŚB 1.2.3.6–9 (verified text): "The gods first offered a man as victim; the sacrificial essence went out of him and entered the horse … the ox … the sheep … the goat … the earth", and it was found as rice and barley. The rejected victims became mongrel beings.
  - In the Kaṭha, Vājaśravas gives away worthless cows; his son Naciketas asks "To whom will you give me?"; in anger the father says "To Death"; the boy goes to Yama's house and wins three boons, the last being the secret of death.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - Gen 22:2–13: the son, the binding (*ʿaqad* ↔ the binding to the post), the knife, the release, the animal substitution.
  - Exod 13:13–15, 22:28–29, 34:20 (redemption of the firstborn); Lev 27:1–8 (vows of persons); Judg 11 (a vow that costs a child).
  - The ŚB substitution chain matches the ideology behind Gen 22:13 and the redemption laws exactly; it is the Vedic theory of why animals stand in for humans.

  Consensus: the parallel is a widely noted, **accepted** comparison, typological, with no contact. The deviations are rich: the god demands the vow, the father is paid, and the son rescues himself by prayer.
- *Soul.* Fathers selling sons in famine; the anxious bargaining with a god; a boy questioning Death.
- *Base text and tools.*
  - AB: TITUS (Aufrecht 1879; **verified** page; no republication); Aufrecht 1879 PD; Haug 1863 (PD; verified archive.org); Keith 1920, *Rigveda Brāhmaṇas* (HOS 25; PD in US; verified archive.org "americana").
  - ŚB: GRETIL (verified). Kaṭha: GRETIL TEI (verified).
  - Translations: Keith; Olivelle 1998 (Kaṭha; ©); Witzel's studies of Śunaḥśepa (reported); Jamison's work on Vedic sacrifice (reported).
  - Hebrew: Fridman 2014 may include parts of the Kaṭha and Brāhmaṇas (verify).
- *Feasibility:* HIGH (easy prose; the embedded gāthās and RV verses are harder).
- *Benefit:* Bible HIGH / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate; it is small and decisive for Gen 22.**

2.4 The early Upaniṣads (selection)

Late Vedic Sanskrit prose and verse · Bṛhadāraṇyaka (BAU) and Chāndogya (CU) c. 7th–6th c. BCE, Kaṭha c. 5th–3rd c. (Olivelle) · oral, then the commentary of Śaṅkara (8th c.) fixes the text · BAU 6 chapters, CU 8 · perfect.

- *What it is.* Teachings in the forest and at royal courts: dialogues of Yājñavalkya with his wives and rivals, Uddālaka with his son Śvetaketu, Indra and the demon Virocana with Prajāpati. They concern the self (*ātman*), *brahman*, breath, death, sleep and dreams.

- *Bible parallels.*
  - **BAU 1.4.1–5** (the core text): "In the beginning this world was the Self alone, in the form of a man (*puruṣa*). He looked around and saw nothing but himself … He was afraid … He found no delight; therefore one alone finds no delight. He desired a second. He was as large as a woman and a man embracing. He split (*apātayat*) this body into two; from it came husband (*pati*) and wife (*patnī*) … therefore Yājñavalkya used to say, 'this body of ours is like one half of a split pea' … He coupled with her, and from that human beings were born." Then she hides as a cow and he becomes a bull, and so on through all the animals.
  - These match Gen 2:18 ("not good that the man be alone"), 2:21–23 (*ṣelaʿ*, the "side" or "half"; one body becomes two) and 2:24 (they become one flesh). The rabbinic androgyne is in Gen. Rabbah 8:1 and *b. Ber.* 61a. The BAU's "animal" sequel is relevant to Gen 2:19–20, the animals passed before the man.
  - BAU 1.2.1 ("In the beginning nothing was here; it was covered by Death, by hunger") ↔ Gen 1:2.
  - CU 6: from Being, heat, water, food; "tat tvam asi" ↔ Deut 6:7, a father teaching his son.
  - CU 8.7–12 (the self in the water-mirror) ↔ Gen 1:26 *ṣelem*.

  Consensus: typological, **accepted** as among the closest Gen 2 analogues. Plato's *Symposium* is the other.
- *Soul.* HIGH. Yājñavalkya and Maitreyī ("not for love of the husband is a husband dear …"), BAU 2.4/4.5. Fear of death; dreams (BAU 4.3).
- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL TEI BAU and CU (with Śaṅkara), Kaṭha (verified). Olivelle 1998, *The Early Upaniṣads: Annotated Text and Translation* (OUP; ©); Olivelle 1996 (OWC). Hume 1921 and Müller SBE 1, 15 (PD). **Hebrew:** Tzachi Fridman, *האופנישדות והברהמנות: מבחר ההגות והמיתולוגיה של הודו הקדומה* (Carmel, 2014; ed. Dalia Tessler; "the first translation of the early Upaniṣads from Sanskrit"; ©). A pirate copy exists on dokumen.pub: do not use.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible HIGH (BAU 1.4) / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate a selection** (BAU 1.1–1.5, 2.4, 3.6–3.9, 4.3–4.5; CU 1.2, 6, 8.7–12; Kaṭha 1). Consult Fridman for register after drafting.

2.5 The Vīdēvdād / Vendidad (selection)

Young Avestan, in a late, partly ungrammatical "school" Avestan · composition debated: older Young Avestan material, redacted perhaps in the Achaemenid period (5th–4th c. BCE) or later · recited in the night-time Vīdēvdād ceremony, which preserved it · earliest manuscripts 1323 CE (L4, K1; reported), from a Sasanian written archetype (5th–6th c. CE) · 22 fargards; ≈ 26,000 words in CAB's corpus without repetitions (counted) · good, with corrupt passages.

- *What it is.* "The law against the demons": questions by Zarathustra and answers by Ahura Mazdā on how to keep the good creation pure from the corpse-demon (*nasu*), dead matter, hair and nails. It covers the dog (its virtues, its feeding, the dog-glance that drives away the corpse-demon), contracts, assault and its penalties, sexual sins, menstruation, and the purification of people and vessels.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - Num 19 (corpse impurity spreads by contact and by "roof"; the purification water) ↔ Vd 5–9: the corpse's contagion, the vessels of earth, wood and metal (↔ Lev 11:32–35, Num 31:20–23), and the nine-night *barəšnūm* purification with bull's urine (*gōmēz*) and water. The red heifer also purifies with a bovine product: typological.
  - Lev 15:19–24, 18:19, 20:18 ↔ Vd 16 (the menstruant's isolation, food and distance from fire and water) and Vd 18 (intercourse with a menstruant as grave sin).
  - Exod 21:18–27 ↔ Vd 4 (graded penalties for threatening, striking, wounding and broken contracts of word, hand, sheep, cow, man and field).
  - Exod 21:22 and 22:15–16 ↔ Vd 15 (seducing a girl, her pregnancy, abortion: the man's liability).
  - Gen 10 ↔ Vd 1: sixteen lands created by Ahura Mazdā, each answered by an affliction from Aŋra Mainyu. It is a geography of peoples; Gen 2:10–14 and the rivers is also relevant.
  - Gen 2:15, 3:17–19 ↔ Vd 3 (who sows grain sows righteousness; the earth's joy).
  - Gen 3 ↔ Vd 19 (Aŋra Mainyu tempts Zarathustra).
  - Deut 21:1–9 ↔ Vd 3 and 6 (corpses buried in the earth pollute the land).

  Consensus: typological similarities are **accepted**. Direct Persian influence on the Priestly purity code is **debated, and mostly rejected** for the core of Lev 11–15, which has ANE roots. Zoroastrian–Jewish interaction is **accepted** for the Babylonian Talmud (Secunda 2014 *The Iranian Talmud*; Secunda 2020 *The Talmud's Red Fence*, on menstrual impurity; reported).
- *Soul.* HIGH: a world in which death is a demon, the dog is holy and the farmer is righteous, and the most intimate bodily facts are cosmic battle-lines.
- *Base text and tools.*
  - Text: CAB basis edition, Vd 1–22 except 11; critical edition only for Vd 8 (verified progress table). Geldner 1896 (PD; TITUS). Andrés-Toledo's critical edition of Vd 19 (2016; ©; reported).
  - Pahlavi version and commentary: Moazami 2014, *Wrestling with the Demons of the Pahlavi Widēwdād* (Brill; ©; reported). Darmesteter, SBE 4 (1880, 2nd ed. 1895; PD; verified archive.org). Wolff 1910, *Avesta* (German translation; PD).
  - Dictionary: Bartholomae (CAB online, PD scan).
  - Hebrew: none found.
- *Feasibility:* MEDIUM. The Young Avestan is formulaic and repetitive, but the Vīdēvdād's grammar is notoriously corrupt and Bartholomae is dated; the Pahlavi Zand and Darmesteter help. LLM risk medium-high: make two review passes against Darmesteter and the Pahlavi.
- *Benefit:* Bible HIGH (law and ritual) / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate Vd 2 (in #2), then 3, 4, 5–8, 15–16**; the rest later.

2.6 The Gāthās and the Yasna Haptaŋhāiti (Old Avestan)

Old Avestan · c. 1200–900 BCE is the majority view, from the language's closeness to the Rigveda and the pastoral world; estimates run from c. 1500 to 600 BCE · oral, preserved inside the Yasna liturgy; earliest mss 1323 CE (J2; reported) · 17 hymns in 5 groups, ≈ 238 stanzas (≈ 5,800 words without repetitions; counted); YH 7 chapters (≈ 900 words) · the text is good, the meaning very uncertain.

- *What it is.* Hymns attributed to Zarathustra: dense, metrical, addressed to Ahura Mazdā and his "Life-giving Immortals" (Truth, Good Thought, Dominion and others). They speak of choice between the two spirits, of the poet-priest's struggle, poverty and patrons, of a final judgment by fire and molten metal, and of the "bridge of the accountant". The YH is a prose liturgy to Ahura Mazdā, the waters, the fire and the earth.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - **Y 44.3–5** ("This I ask you, tell me truly, Lord: who in the beginning was father of Truth? Who set the path of sun and stars? … who holds the earth below and the sky from falling? … who yoked the swift steeds to wind and clouds? … What craftsman made light and darkness, sleep and waking? Who made dawn, noon and night?") ↔ Gen 1:3–5, 14–18; Job 38; Isa 40:12–26, 45:7 ("forming light and creating darkness"). Morton Smith 1963 (JAOS) argued that Deutero-Isaiah knew this; the contact is **debated**.
  - **Y 37.1 (YH):** "Thus we worship Ahura Mazdā, who created the cow and Truth, created the waters and the good plants, created the lights and the earth and all good things" ↔ the elements of Gen 1 in liturgy, c. 1000 BCE.
  - **Y 30.2–5:** the choice between the two spirits ("the good and the bad … the wise chose rightly") ↔ Deut 30:15–19, Gen 2:17 (the knowledge of good and evil).
  - Y 45, 48 ↔ the end-time judgment, which is not in the Torah.
- *Soul.* HIGH. Y 46.1–2: "To which land shall I flee? Where shall I go? They push me away from family and clan … I know why I am powerless: I have few cattle and few men." Y 29, "the lament of the cow's soul" before the gods.
- *Base text and tools.* CAB: the YH is critically edited (Y 35–41 ✓), Y 47–50 critically edited; Y 28–34, 43–46 and 51, 53 basis edition only (verified). Geldner (PD; TITUS). Bartholomae 1904 (PD; CAB online). Translations, to be set side by side in a variorum:
  - Insler 1975;
  - Humbach 1991 (with Elfenbein and Skjærvø);
  - Humbach & Faiss 2010;
  - Kellens & Pirart 1988–91;
  - West 2010, *The Hymns of Zoroaster*;
  - Skjærvø's translations and *Old Avestan* teaching materials (the Harvard pages were 403/404 today);
  - Narten 1986 and Hintze 2007 (*A Zoroastrian Liturgy*) for the YH.

  All ©. Hebrew: none found; he.wikipedia has only a sample (verify via the NLI catalogue).
- *Feasibility:* LOW–MEDIUM. Experts disagree on whole stanzas, and an LLM's guesses are unsafe. The cognate Vedic helps, but the honest product is a **variorum translation**: our rendering plus a column of alternatives and the cruxes marked. The YH is much easier, with a critical edition and plainer prose.
- *Benefit:* Bible MED-HIGH / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* **translate the YH (now) and Y 44, 30, 46, 29 (carefully, variorum)**. The rest of the Gāthās only with a specialist edition in hand.

2.7 The Atharvaveda (selection)

Vedic · Śaunaka recension c. 1200–900 BCE (late Rigvedic to early Brāhmaṇa language), oral; Paippalāda recension transmitted in Orissa and Kashmir (the Kashmir birch-bark ms c. 16th c.; reported) · Śaunaka 20 books, ≈ 730 hymns, ≈ 6,000 stanzas · good.

- *What it is.* The Veda of charms and of household and royal rites: spells against fever, worms, snakes, rivals in love and demons; for conception, long life, a husband or a wife, and victory; hymns to Earth, Time, the Brahmacārin and the Vrātya; book 18 on funerals.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - Num 5:11–31: the cursing waters, AV curses and ordeals; typological.
  - Lev 13: *kilāsa*, white skin disease, AV 1.23–24.
  - Exod 22:17, Deut 18:10–11: the practices the Torah forbids, seen from inside.
  - Gen 25:21, 30:14–16: fertility charms and plants.
  - Gen 1:11–12, 2:7: AV 12.1, the Earth hymn (63 st.), on earth as mother.
- *Soul.* HIGH, the closest Indian counterpart to Maqlû and the Mesopotamian love incantations already in the corpus.
- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL Śaunaka (Orlandi 1991 / Roth–Whitney 1856; accented and unaccented versions) and the **Paippalāda TEI** (Griffiths, Zehnder, Lubotsky and others, 2.5 MB, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0; verified). Translations: Whitney–Lanman 1905 (HOS 7–8; PD; verified archive.org), Bloomfield 1897 SBE 42 (PD; verified archive.org), and the Paippalāda volumes by Zehnder, Lubotsky, Griffiths, Lopez, Kim and Selva (some open access; reported). Hebrew: none found.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible MEDIUM / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate about 60 hymns as "charms and prayers of daily life", paired with Maqlû and the Mesopotamian love incantations.

2.8 The Yašts and the Hōm Yašt (Y 9)

Young Avestan · hymns with old Indo-Iranian myth (Mithra = Vedic Mitra; Θraētaona = Vedic Trita Āptya; Yima = Yama) · oral, perhaps c. 900–500 BCE · mss 14th c.+ · 21 Yašts plus Y 9 · good, some corrupt.

- *What it is.*
  - **Yt 10:** Mithra, the god of the contract, with "a thousand ears and ten thousand eyes", who smashes the "contract-breaker" (*miθrō.druj*).
  - **Yt 8:** the star Tištrya (Sirius) as a white horse fights the drought-demon Apaoša, a black horse, for the rains.
  - **Yt 5:** Arədvī Sūrā Anāhitā, the river goddess, and the heroes who sacrificed to her.
  - **Yt 19:** the royal Glory (*xᵛarənah*), which leaves Yima when he lies.
  - **Yt 13:** the *fravašis*, the souls, and Gaya Marətan, the first man.
  - **Yt 22 (Hādōxt Nask):** the soul after death meets its own religious self as a beautiful maiden, or a hag.
  - **Y 9:** Haoma; Yima's reign without heat, cold, old age or death; Θraētaona kills the three-headed dragon Aži Dahāka; Kərəsāspa kills the horned dragon.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - Gen 1:21 and Leviathan: Aži Dahāka and the sea-monster Gandarəβa in the Vourukaša sea (Yt 5, 19).
  - Gen 2–3 and 3:22–24: Yima's deathless reign and loss of glory through a lie (Yt 19.33–38).
  - Gen 9:8–17 and Deut 28: Mithra as the guarantor of oaths, with the curse on the breaker.
  - Gen 8:22, Deut 11:14: the rains and seasons.
  - Gen 1:26, 2:7: Gaya Marətan, literally "mortal life", the first man; Hebrew Ḥawwāh is also "life".

  Typological; **accepted** as Indo-Iranian inheritance.
- *Soul.* HIGH: epic hymns, ecstatic, visual; the Hādōxt soul-maiden is one of the finest ancient images of conscience.
- *Base text and tools.* CAB, which includes YtMihr, YtTish, Yt Ābān and YtZam (verified in the corpus). Geldner (PD). Darmesteter SBE 23 (PD; verified archive.org). Modern translations and studies (©): Gershevitch 1959 (Yt 10), Panaino 1990–95 (Yt 8), Hintze 1994 (Yt 19), Malandra 1983 (anthology), Skjærvø's readers (reported).
- *Feasibility:* MEDIUM (formulaic; Bartholomae). *Benefit:* Bible MEDIUM / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate Y 9, Yt 10 (selections), Yt 8, Yt 19.30–44, Yt 22 as a "myths of Iran" corpus.

2.9 The Aggañña Sutta and the old Sutta Nipāta

Pali · the Buddha's lifetime is c. 480–400 BCE; oral, recited by "reciters" (bhāṇaka); written down in Sri Lanka in the 1st c. BCE · surviving Pali mss mostly 18th–19th c. (the Gāndhārī birch-bark scrolls of the 1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE are the oldest Buddhist mss; see §3) · DN 27 ≈ 32 §§; Sutta Nipāta 71 suttas, ≈ 1,149 verses · perfect.

- *What it is.* DN 27 is the Buddha's ironic counter-Genesis for two Brahmin converts. At a world-cycle's beginning beings are self-luminous and feed on joy. A savoury earth spreads over the waters; one greedy being tastes it, the others follow, their light fades, and sun and moon appear. Their bodies coarsen; the earth-savour vanishes and is replaced by plants and then rice. Sex differences appear, then lust, then houses to hide in, then hoarding, theft, lying and punishment. The people elect a "Great Elect" (*mahāsammata*), the first king, and so arise the four classes. The Sutta Nipāta's Aṭṭhakavagga and Pārāyanavagga are considered among the oldest Buddhist poetry (quoted by name in other canonical texts).
- *Bible parallels* (DN 27). Gen 2–3: a primal state lost through eating, then shame and hiding (↔ 3:7–10), sexual differentiation, labour for food (3:17–19). Gen 4:17–22: houses, fields, crafts. 1 Sam 8: the people choose a king. Consensus: typological, no contact; a classic comparison (Collins 1993, *JPTS*; reported).
- *Soul.* HIGH: wit, satire of caste pride; the ascetic voice of the Aṭṭhakavagga, which renounces argument itself.
- *Base text and tools.* **SuttaCentral bilara-data** (GitHub raw): Pali root (Mahāsaṅgīti) and Sujato's English, both **CC0** (README verified; DN 27 and Snp 4.1 files verified). PTS Pali–English Dictionary (1921–25, PD; DSAL, verified host); Digital Pali Dictionary (CC; host blocked today); Norman, *The Group of Discourses* (PTS; ©); Walshe, DN (©). Hebrew: DN 27 and Snp not found in Hebrew (verify; there are online Hebrew sutta translations by Dharma groups).
- *Feasibility:* HIGH (Pali is well resourced; an LLM handles it well). *Benefit:* Bible MED-HIGH / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate DN 27 whole, and the Aṭṭhakavagga.

2.10 The Dharmasūtras (Āpastamba, Gautama, Baudhāyana, Vasiṣṭha)

Sanskrit aphoristic prose · c. 3rd–1st c. BCE (Olivelle; older estimates earlier) · from Vedic ritual schools · mss 2nd millennium CE · ≈ 3,500 sūtras · good.

- *What it is.* The earliest Brahmanical law books: student life, the householder, food, impurity, penance, kingship, theft, assault, adultery, inheritance, witnesses and the duties of the classes.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - **Lev 11 / Deut 14.** Āpastamba 1.17.37 and Gautama 17: of five-nailed animals only five may be eaten (porcupine, hedgehog, hare, tortoise, iguana or monitor lizard). Rules for fish and birds; forbidden carnivorous birds. Typological, but strikingly similar in *form*: lists plus criteria.
  - **Lev 12, Num 19.** Impurity after birth and death (10 days for Brahmins, longer for others; graded by kinship), and touching a corpse.
  - **Deut 25:5–10.** *Niyoga*: a brother-in-law raises a son for the dead or impotent husband (Gautama 18; Vasiṣṭha 17).
  - **Deut 21:15–17.** The eldest son's extra share (Āpastamba 2.14; Gautama 28; Manu 9.112–117).
  - **Exod 21–22.** Theft, assault and damage to cattle and fields.
  - **Lev 19:9–10.** Gleaning; the *uñchavṛtti*.
  - **Lev 5.** Expiations (*prāyaścitta*).
- *Soul.* MEDIUM: the minute regulation of daily life.

- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL TEI for all four (verified listing; Āpastamba 123 KB). Bühler, SBE 2 and 14 (PD; verified archive.org). Olivelle 2000, *Dharmasūtras: The Law Codes of Āpastamba, Gautama, Baudhāyana and Vasiṣṭha* (critical edition and translation; Motilal; ©). Hebrew: none found.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH (terse sūtra style; clear). *Benefit:* Bible HIGH (law) / Soul MEDIUM. *Recommendation:* translate thematic selections keyed to Lev 11–15 and Deut 21–25, as a counterpart to the חוקים-ובריתות corpus.

2.11 Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa: cosmogonies and the animal sacrifice

Vedic prose · c. 8th–6th c. BCE · 14 books (Mādhyandina) · good.

- *What it is.* The "Brāhmaṇa of a hundred paths" explains each act of the great rituals through myths, etymologies and identifications.
- *Bible parallels.*
  - ŚB 6.1.1 (Prajāpati alone, desiring to be many) and 11.1.6.1 ("In the beginning this was water, a flood (*salila*); the waters desired … a golden egg … after a year a man, Prajāpati") ↔ Gen 1:2.
  - ŚB 14.1.2.11 (the boar Emūṣa raises the earth from the waters) ↔ Gen 1:9.
  - ŚB 3.7–3.8, the animal sacrifice: the victim is strangled; the omentum (*vapā*) is cut out and offered first; then the portions; blood to the demons ↔ Lev 1, 3:3–4 (the *ḥelev* "that covers the entrails"), Lev 7:30–34, Lev 17:11–14 (blood).
  - ŚB 1.6.3 (Indra's slaying of Vṛtra) ↔ Gen 1:21.
  - Typological; very concrete for Lev 1–7.
- *Soul.* MEDIUM (11.5.1, Purūravas and Urvaśī, HIGH).
- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL (Weber's text, unaccented; **some passages have data-entry gaps "..."**, seen in 1.2.3.6; verified); TITUS (accented; no republication); Weber 1855 (PD; reported). Eggeling SBE 12, 26, 41, 43, 44 (PD; verified archive.org). Schwab 1886, *Das altindische Thieropfer* (PD; reported).
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible MED-HIGH / Soul MEDIUM. *Recommendation:* translate the cosmogonies with #1, and 3.7–3.8 for Leviticus.

2.12 Old Tamil Sangam poetry

Old Tamil · the core anthologies c. 1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE (by language, Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions, Roman trade), anthologized c. 5th–8th c. with colophons · transmitted on palm leaf, mss 17th–19th c.; rediscovered and printed 1887–1915 (C. W. Thamotharam Pillai, U. V. Swaminatha Iyer; reported) · Eight Anthologies + Ten Idylls: ≈ 2,380 poems, ≈ 26,000 lines, ≈ 470 poets, some women (Auvaiyār) · good.

- *What it is.* Two genres: *akam* ("inner": love) and *puṟam* ("outer": war, kings, death, ethics). Each love-poem is a monologue by a stock speaker (the heroine, her friend, the hero) set in one of five landscapes (*tiṇai*), each with its mood. The hills (*kuṟiñci*) mean union, the seashore (*neytal*) anxious waiting, and the desert (*pālai*) separation. A hearer decoded flowers, birds and seasons as emotion. The GRETIL text gives tiṇai and speaker headings for each poem (verified).
- *Bible parallels.* None for the Torah. The Song of Songs' landscape and flower codes and its female speaker are a typological parallel. Hebrew *tukkiyyim* (1 Kgs 10:22, "peacocks") is often derived from Tamil *tōkai*: a real but **debated** trade contact.
- *Soul.* HIGH, among the most refined love poetry of antiquity. Puṟanāṉūṟu 192: "Every town is our town, every man our kin." Elegies for kings; the bard's poverty.
- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL mirrors Project Madurai in ISO romanization: Kuṟuntokai PM0110 (verified), Puṟanāṉūṟu PM0057, Aiṅkuṟunūṟu PM0028, the Ten Idylls and others. Project Madurai is open (licence "free distribution", reported); its Naṟṟiṇai includes an English translation (seen in its list).
  - Critical editions: Eva Wilden, Kuṟuntokai (2010, 3 vols) and Naṟṟiṇai (2008; EFEO and Tamilmann; ©; reported).
  - Dictionaries and grammar: *Tamil Lexicon* (Madras 1924–36; DSAL online; verified host); Wilden's *Grammar of Old Tamil* (2018; verify).
  - Translations: Ramanujan, *Poems of Love and War* (1985; ©); Hart & Heifetz, *The Four Hundred Songs of War and Wisdom* (1999; ©); Vaidehi Herbert's complete translations, free to read online (learnsangamtamil.com, verified 200; ©).
  - **Hebrew:** David Shulman, *דקדוק האהבה: שירה טמילית עתיקה* (Carmel). e-vrit lists Feb 2026, 202 pp.; an earlier Carmel edition c. 2012 (the "2" in one title may mean a second volume or edition; verify). A pirate copy is on dokumen.pub: do not use.
- *Feasibility:* MEDIUM. Old Tamil is far harder than modern Tamil, and LLM competence is uneven; the medieval commentaries (Nacciṉārkkiṉiyar and others) and the Tamil Lexicon help. The poems are short, so errors stay local.
- *Benefit:* Bible LOW / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate Kuṟuntokai whole (401 short poems) plus about 80 Puṟanāṉūṟu. Consult Shulman after drafting.

2.13 The Therīgāthā (and Theragāthā)

Pali · verses attributed to the first Buddhist nuns, c. 5th–3rd c. BCE oral; written 1st c. BCE · 73 poems, ≈ 522 verses (Thag 264 poems, 1,279 verses) · perfect.

- *What it is.* Short poems of release: from a crooked husband, "mortar and pestle" (Mutta); grief for dead children (Kisā Gotamī, Paṭācārā); the courtesan Ambapālī's portrait of her ageing body ("my hair was black as bees … now like hemp"); Subhā's eye plucked out for a pursuer.
- *Bible parallels.* None direct.
- *Soul.* HIGH: arguably the oldest anthology of women's poetry in India (the claim is debated, since monks may have shaped it).

- *Base text and tools.* SuttaCentral (Pali + Sujato English, CC0; Thig 1.1 file verified); GRETIL. Hallisey 2015, *Therigatha: Poems of the First Buddhist Women* (Murty Classical Library, Pali text and translation; ©); Norman (PTS; ©). Hebrew: selections by Keren Sheffi online (kerensheffi.com, "מבחר שירים של נזירות בודהיסטיות קדומות"); no complete translation found.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible LOW / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate whole (small).

2.14 Aśoka's edicts

Prakrit in regional dialects (Māgadhī-type in the east, Gāndhārī in Kharoṣṭhī script in the north-west) + Greek and Aramaic at Kandahar · 268–232 BCE · the original inscriptions survive: the earliest deciphered Indian writing · ≈ 35 texts with many versions · mostly well preserved.

- *What it is.* A Mauryan emperor's messages carved on rocks and pillars: remorse after conquering Kalinga, with "a hundred thousand slain" (Rock Edict 13); a programme of *dhamma*; limits on killing animals in the royal kitchen (RE 1); hospitals for people and beasts, wells and shade trees (RE 2, PE 7); officers of morality; tolerance of sects (RE 12).
- *Bible parallels.* LOW–MEDIUM: Deut 17:14–20 (the moral king), Lev 17 and Deut 12:15–21 (sacrifice and profane slaughter), Deut 22:6–7 and 25:4 (care for animals). The Kandahar Aramaic version is in Imperial Aramaic: a link to the Levant scope.
- *Soul.* MED-HIGH: a rare first-person royal conscience.
- *Base text and tools.* Hultzsch 1925, CII vol. I (Public Domain Mark on archive.org; verified). Bloch 1950 (French; ©). Falk 2006, *Aśokan Sites and Artefacts* (©). Siddham (siddham.network, host 200; Indic inscriptions database, coverage of Aśoka to verify). Norman's papers. Hebrew: none found.
- *Feasibility:* MED-HIGH: dialect variants, but small and well studied. *Benefit:* Bible LOW–MEDIUM / Soul MED-HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate the Major Rock Edicts in one version (Girnār or Kālsī) with variants, plus PE 7 and the Kandahar bilingual.

2.15 Mahābhārata selections

Epic Sanskrit · a bardic oral epic; growth c. 400 BCE–400 CE; the BORI critical edition (1933–66) reconstructs the c. 4th-c. CE text · ≈ 75,000 ślokas in the critical edition; book 3 = 10,234 verse-lines, counted in GRETIL · perfect.

- *What it is.* The war of the Bhāratas, filled with tales told in the forest exile (book 3).
  - *Sāvitrī* (3.277–283, 297 ślokas): a wife follows Death (Yama) and wins back her husband by argument.
  - *Nala and Damayantī* (3.50–78, 901): a king loses all at dice and wanders, and his wife finds him.
  - *Ṛṣyaśṛṅga* (3.110–113, 101): a hermit's son who has never seen a woman is lured out by a courtesan to bring rain. This is close to Enkidu and Šamḫat in Gilgameš I (already translated here!).
  - *Śibi and the dove* (3.130–131, 52): the king offers his own flesh to save a dove from a hawk.
  - *The Yakṣa's questions* (3.297–298, 102): riddles at a lake.
  - *Matsya* (3.185): see §2.2.
- *Bible parallels.* LOW–MEDIUM: Ṛṣyaśṛṅga ↔ Gen 38 and Gilgameš; Sāvitrī ↔ Song 8:6. The Bhagavad Gītā (6.23–40) is outside our purposes.
- *Soul.* HIGH.
- *Base text and tools.* GRETIL (Smith's e-text of the critical edition; "reference only"; verified). The van Buitenen / Fitzgerald Chicago translation (©). Ganguli 1883–96 (PD). **Hebrew:** Ithamar Theodor, *הבהגוד גיטא* (Carmel 2002). Ofira Gamliel, *שיוה ביער האורנים* (Keter 1999) and *יוגים, מלכים ונשים שמימיות* (Keter 2001), retold Indian myths (verify whether translated). Amram Peter, (2001) *המיתולוגיה ההודית*. No full Nala or Sāvitrī found.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible LOW–MEDIUM / Soul HIGH. *Recommendation:* translate Ṛṣyaśṛṅga (it links to Gilgameš) and Sāvitrī; Nala later.

2.16 The Bundahišn (flagged: late)

Middle Persian (Pahlavi script) · redacted 9th c. CE (two recensions: the Indian and the longer Iranian, "Greater" Bundahišn), from the Zand (translation and commentary) of lost Avestan nasks, especially the Dāmdād · mss 14th–16th c. (verify) · ≈ 36 chapters · good.

- *What it is.* The Zoroastrian book of creation and the end. Ohrmazd creates first in spirit, then in matter, in **six stages** (sky, water, earth, plants, the Uniquely-created Bull, the first man Gayōmard), celebrated as the six *gāhānbār* feasts over a year. Ahriman attacks; from the dead Gayōmard's seed grows a rhubarb plant that becomes the first couple, Mašī and Mašyānē. Ahriman deceives them; they declare that he made the world, and they eat, dress in skins and quarrel. The text then covers the peopling of the seven regions, the heroes and the end.
- *Bible parallels.* Gen 1 (six stages, ending in man), Gen 2:7 and 2:21–23 (first couple from one plant), Gen 3 (the lie, eating, clothing), Gen 10 (peoples). Consensus: the old Iranian core (creation lists, the six seasonal feasts in Avestan, Gaya Marətan) is **accepted** as pre-Islamic. But the 9th-c. redaction lived among Jews, Christians and Muslims, so any detail close to Genesis is suspect of influence in either direction. Use it as a flagged control, never as evidence of Iranian influence on Genesis.
- *Soul.* MEDIUM.
- *Base text and tools.* TITUS Indian Bundahišn (verified frame page; no republication). West, SBE 5 (1880, PD; verified archive.org "Pahlavi texts"). Anklesaria 1956 (text and translation of the Greater Bundahišn; status unclear). Pakzad 2005 (critical edition; ©). Agostini & Thrope 2020, *The Bundahišn: The Zoroastrian Book of Creation* (OUP; ©). Tools: MacKenzie, *Concise Pahlavi Dictionary* (1971; ©). The MPCD (Middle Persian Corpus and Dictionary) host returned 418 / 308 today.
- *Feasibility:* LOW–MEDIUM; the script is ambiguous, so work from a transcription. *Benefit:* Bible MEDIUM (late) / Soul MEDIUM. *Recommendation:* a short, flagged selection (creation and the first couple) as an appendix to the Avestan corpus.

2.17 Old Persian royal inscriptions

Old Persian cuneiform (invented under Darius I, c. 520 BCE) · 520–338 BCE · originals, many trilingual (Old Persian–Elamite–Akkadian); the Bisitun text also survives in an Aramaic papyrus copy from Elephantine (TAD C2.1) · whole corpus ≈ 6,000 words (verify) · good.

- *What it is.* Royal proclamations: Darius' account of his seizure of power against "the Lie" (DB, ≈ 76 §§); his tomb inscriptions (DNa: the lands, "Ahuramazdā, when he saw this earth in turmoil, bestowed it on me"; DNb: "what is right I love, I am not a friend to the man who follows the Lie"); building texts (DSf, Susa: materials from every land, ↔ Exod 35, 1 Kgs 5); Xerxes' daiva inscription (XPh: suppression of demon-worship).
- *Bible parallels.* Torah LOW (Gen 10:2 Madai, 10:22 Elam). Elsewhere MEDIUM:
  - Ezra 1, 4–7 (decrees; *dāta*, Ezra 7:12–26);
  - Esther 1:1 (the provinces), 1:19, 8:8–10 (law that cannot be revoked; *aḥašdarpenim* ← *xšaçapāvan*);
  - Dan 6.

  The "Persian imperial authorization" of the Torah (Frei 1984) is **debated**.
- *Soul.* MEDIUM.
- *Base text and tools.* TITUS Old Persian corpus (Kent / Mayrhofer / Schmitt; Old Persian script plus transliteration; verified; no republication). Livius (English, verified; licence ©, older translations). King & Thompson 1907 (PD; reported). Kent 1953, *Old Persian* (archive.org **lending-only**, verified; an unrestricted upload "oldpers" is of unclear authorization: avoid). Schmitt 1991 (CII Bisitun) and 2009 (©). Lecoq 1997. ORACC's Achaemenid Royal Inscriptions project (reported; ORACC unreachable today, TLS). Hebrew: Porten & Yardeni's TAD gives Hebrew and English for the Aramaic DB (reported); no Hebrew Old Persian edition found.
- *Feasibility:* HIGH. *Benefit:* Bible LOW (Torah) / Soul MEDIUM. *Recommendation:* translate DB, DNa, DNb and XPh, about 1,800 words, as a short appendix; coordinate with the Levant agent for the Aramaic DB.

2.18 Parthian and Middle Persian survivals of oral literature

- **Draxt ī Asūrīg** ("The Assyrian Tree"): a verse contest between a date-palm and a goat over who is more useful. It is Parthian in origin (oral, c. 1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE), written in Pahlavi, ≈ 120 verses. It continues the **Sumerian debate genre**, so it could be read beside the Debate between Bird and Fish (already translated). Editions: Brunner 1980 and others (©; reported).
- **Ayādgār ī Zarērān**: a Parthian minstrel epic of Zarēr's death in the holy war, ≈ 114 §§, the core of Šāhnāme episodes.
- **Ardā Wirāz Nāmag**: a righteous man's visionary tour of heaven and hell (redacted 9th–10th c.; ↔ Enoch and apocalyptic). Haug–Hoshangji 1872 (PD); Vahman 1986, Gignoux 1984 (©).

Soul MEDIUM, Bible LOW–MEDIUM; Pahlavi risk HIGH. *Recommendation:* Draxt ī Asūrīg only, if a reliable transcription is in hand.

2.19 Elamite: Persepolis tablets and royal inscriptions

Achaemenid Elamite · Persepolis Fortification Tablets (PFT) 509–493 BCE, Treasury Tablets 492–458 BCE · Middle Elamite royal inscriptions (c. 1400–1100 BCE: Untaš-Napiriša, Šutruk-Naḫḫunte) · originals.

- *What it is.* Administrative records of rations for workers, travellers, horses and the cult, including rations for Iranian gods and Elamite Humban. The royal texts are building and booty inscriptions.
- *Bible parallels.* LOW. Gen 10:22 and 14:1 (Chedorlaomer, an Elamite-type name *Kutir-*); Ezra 4:9. A curious typological note: in the PFT, mothers received a birth ration that was larger for a boy than for a girl (Brosius 1996; verify). It is the mirror image of Lev 12:2–5's longer purity period for a girl.
- *Soul.* MEDIUM: daily economic life of the Persian heartland.
- *Base text and tools.* Hallock 1969, OIP 92 (free PDF from ISAC, 58.8 MB, verified). Cameron 1948, OIP 65 (Treasury; reported free). The Persepolis Fortification Archive project, on OCHRE (host 200). König 1965 for the royal inscriptions (©). Elamite is **poorly understood**: Hinz–Koch 1987, *Elamisches Wörterbuch* (©).
- *Feasibility:* LOW. *Benefit:* Bible LOW / Soul MEDIUM. *Recommendation:* not now; at most a sampler drawn from Hallock's own translations.

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3. Also considered

- **Rāmāyaṇa** (Vālmīki; c. 5th c. BCE–1st c. CE; GRETIL critical-edition text): 1.2, the *krauñca* bird and the birth of the *śloka* from grief (soul HIGH, short); Ṛṣyaśṛṅga 1.8–10. Runner-up. The Hebrew "ראמאינה" on ybook is from Venkatesananda's English, not from Sanskrit.
- **Manusmṛti** (c. 2nd c. CE; GRETIL TEI verified; Olivelle 2005 ©): Manu 1 (the golden egg on the waters; Brahmā splits his body into male and female halves, 1.32 ↔ Gen 1:27) and Manu 8–9 (law) are relevant but late. Use as a secondary control to the Dharmasūtras.
- **Purāṇic flood** (Matsya Purāṇa 1–2; Bhāgavata 8.24): later (c. 3rd–10th c. CE) elaborations of the Matsya story. Appendix only.
- **Bhaviṣya Purāṇa, Pratisargaparvan** ("Adama and Havyavatī", "Nyūha" = Noah): a late interpolation (probably 18th–19th c.). **Avoid** as ancient tradition.

- **Hoaxes and forgeries to avoid:**
  - the *Ezourvedam* (an 18th-c. Jesuit fabrication of a "Veda");
  - the *Dasātīr* (a 17th-c. Persian forgery of "ancient prophets");
  - Notovitch's *Unknown Life of Jesus* (1894);
  - the *Vaimānika Śāstra* (1952);
  - Jacolliot's Bible-in-India books (19th c.).
- **Indus (Harappan) inscriptions:** undeciphered. Exclude.
- **Gāndhārī Buddhist manuscripts** (birch-bark, 1st c. BCE–3rd c. CE; the oldest South Asian manuscripts: the Gāndhārī Dharmapada, the Rhinoceros Sutra, etc.): important as the earliest witnesses, but fragmentary and highly specialized. `gandhari.org` was unreachable today. Revisit for the Dhammapada.
- **Dhammapada** (Pali, 423 verses): already in Hebrew (Asaf Federman, *דברי אמת (דהמפדה)*, Pardes 2011, "the first Hebrew translation from the Pali"; an earlier biblical-Hebrew version by Zelikovitch is mentioned; verify). Lower priority.
- **Bhagavad Gītā:** in Hebrew (Theodor 2002); a philosophical epic insertion; outside both purposes' priorities.
- **Jātaka** (prose commentary 5th c. CE; verses older): Mahosadha's "judgment" of two women claiming a child (Jātaka 546) ↔ 1 Kgs 3:16–28. A famous parallel, but late and outside the Torah. Possibly an excerpt.
- **Jaina Ācārāṅga I** (Ardhamāgadhī, c. 4th–3rd c. BCE; GRETIL `2_prakrt/ayarangu.htm` verified; Jacobi SBE 22 PD): radical non-violence (soul MEDIUM). Later round.
- **Gṛhyasūtras and Śrautasūtras:** life-cycle rites (birth ↔ Lev 12; marriage; funeral) and the detail of sacrifice (↔ Lev 1–7). Supplements to #10 and #11.
- **Jaiminīya Brāhmaṇa:** rich old myths (Bodewitz's translations, ©); the text is on TITUS (reported). Mine for single stories later.
- **Kauṣītaki and Pañcaviṃśa Brāhmaṇas, Taittirīya Saṃhitā** (the boar raising the earth TS 7.1.5): secondary witnesses (GRETIL TEI for Kauṣītaki and Pañcaviṃśa, verified).
- **Arthaśāstra, Kāmasūtra, Tirukkuṟaḷ, Cilappatikāram:** too late (1st–6th c. CE) for this round.
- **Tolkāppiyam** (Old Tamil grammar and poetics; date disputed, 2nd c. BCE–5th c. CE): a tool for the Sangam corpus, not a candidate.
- **Avestan Nirangistān / Hērbedestān** (priestly law, in Avestan with Pahlavi): small, technical (Kotwal–Kreyenbroek ©). Later, for Lev 8–10.
- **Zand ī Wahman Yasn** (four ages of metals ↔ Dan 2): late (9th–10th c.); outside the Torah.
- **Šāhnāme** (Firdawsi, 1010 CE): preserves old Iranian epic but is a medieval literary work. Shaul Shaked appears as scholarly editor of a Hebrew Šāhnāme (reported). Out of scope.
- **Cyrus Cylinder:** Akkadian, so already in the Mesopotamian scope (Ezra 1 ↔ the restoration of temples).
- **Mitanni Indo-Aryan** (the Šattiwaza treaty's Mitra–Varuṇa–Indra–Nāsatya; the Kikkuli horse-training terms): in Hittite and Akkadian documents; for the Anatolian/Mesopotamian agents. They are the earliest datable evidence of Vedic gods (c. 1380 BCE).
- **Sri Lankan chronicles** (Dīpavaṃsa, Mahāvaṃsa, 4th–5th c. CE): late.
- **Middle Elamite royal inscriptions:** poorly understood; low value.

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4. Access notes

4.1 Hosts tested (`curl -s -o /dev/null -m 20 -w "%{http_code}"`, 2026-10-21)

Host	Result	Notes
gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de	**200**	Index (1 MB) parsed; SB 1, MBh 3, Kuṛuntokai, Paippalāda, AV Śaunaka, BAU, CU, Kaṭha, Āpastamba, Manu, Therīgāthā and Ācārāṅga fetched or checked (verified).
vedaweb.uni-koeln.de	**200**	SPA; the API path `/rigveda/api/...` returns HTML. Use GitHub instead.
raw.githubusercontent.com	**200**	Works for VedaWebProject/vedaweb-data (TEI books 1–10, verified), sanskrit-lexicon/csl-orig (MW, Grassmann, PW, Apte, BHS; verified) and suttacentral/bilara-data (verified). `OliverHellwig/sanskrit` (DCS data) paths 404 (repo layout unknown).
github.com / api.github.com / codeload	403	"Sessions are bound to their configured repositories". Raw works; the API, search and zip downloads do not.
titus.uni-frankfurt.de	**000** (reset); http 503	Main host down or blocked.
titus.fkidg1.uni-frankfurt.de	**200**	Mirror works: Avesta (Geldner), Old Persian, Aitareya Br., ŚB Mādhyandina, Indian Bundahišn (verified pages). Not every path is real: a bogus path also returns 200. Terms: "No parts ... may be republished ... without prior permission". Use locally only.
cab.geschkult.fu-berlin.de	**200**	eXist app; corpus `.../exist/apps/cab/modules/get_corpus_plain.xql` (1.3 MB, verified), also `_xml`/`_json`. Bartholomae online. Work-progress table parsed. Licence: footer "Corpus Avesticum Berolinense CC" with no version stated: verify.
ada.geschkult.fu-berlin.de	200	Avestan Digital Archive manuscript viewer (new host).
ada.usal.es	000 (proxy 502)	Old ADA host.
www.avesta.org	000	**TLS certificate expired** (http → https redirect). WebFetch 503. Not usable without disabling verification (not done).
sacred-texts.com	200 root; **403** sub-pages	Blocks scripts. Use archive.org for SBE.
archive.org	**200**	advancedsearch and metadata APIs work. PD items verified: Darmesteter SBE 4/23, Griffith RV, Eggeling SBE 12/26/43, Keith 1920 (AB/KB), Bartholomae 1904, Whitney–Lanman 1905, Bloomfield 1897, Hultzsch 1925 (PD mark), Bühler SBE 2, West Pahlavi Texts, Grassmann 1873, Geldner 1951 (PD mark item). **Kent 1953 is lending-only.**
isac.uchicago.edu	**200**	OIP 92 (Hallock) PDF on isac-assets.s3.amazonaws.com, 58.8 MB, application/pdf (verified HEAD).
www.sanskrit-linguistics.org (DCS)	**200**	Online corpus and dictionary.
www.sanskrit-lexicon.uni-koeln.de	**403** (also with a browser UA)	Use csl-orig on GitHub raw.
rigvedacommentary.alc.ucla.edu	**200**	Jamison's commentary PDFs for books 1–10 (uploads dated 2026-09).
suttacentral.net	**200**	API `/api/suttas/snp1.1` 200; bilara-data on GitHub raw is the better route (CC0).
tipitaka.org, digitalpalireader.online	200	—
dpd.digitalpalidictionary.com	000 (proxy refused)	—
dsal.uchicago.edu	**200**	Tamil Lexicon, PTS Pali dictionary.
www.projectmadurai.org	200	Some deep paths 404; use the GRETIL mirrors.
learnsangamtamil.com	200	Vaidehi Herbert's translations (©).
tamilvu.org, tamildigitallibrary.in	200	—

Host	Result	Notes
www.livius.org	**200**	Behistun English (verified).
siddham.network	200	Indic inscriptions.
ochre.lib.uchicago.edu	200	PFA.
oracc.museum.upenn.edu / oracc.org	**000**	"SSL certificate problem: unable to get local issuer certificate". Note for any Achaemenid ORACC project.
www.sarit.info, gandhari.org, achemenet.com, ebooks.iranicaonline.org, kjc-sv013 (Heidelberg)	000	Proxy 502 or connection reset.
iranicaonline.org	403	Even with a browser UA.
fas.harvard.edu/~iranian (Skjærvø)	403 / 404	—
mpcorpus.org	418 / 308	—
academia.edu	403	—

4.2 Hosts a future session needs in its allowlist

gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de, raw.githubusercontent.com, titus.fkidg1.uni-frankfurt.de, cab.geschkult.fu-berlin.de, ada.geschkult.fu-berlin.de, archive.org, isac.uchicago.edu, isac-assets.s3.amazonaws.com, rigvedacommentary.alc.ucla.edu, suttacentral.net, dsal.uchicago.edu, www.sanskrit-linguistics.org.

Desirable if they can be fixed: www.sanskrit-lexicon.uni-koeln.de, gandhari.org, www.sarit.info, iranicaonline.org, avesta.org (its certificate must be renewed by the site).

4.3 Licences (for the public repo, guidelines §8)

Source	Licence	Can it be committed?
VedaWeb	per layer, CC BY 4.0 or CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 (verified)	yes, with attribution, like ETCSL
GRETIL TEI files	mostly CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 (verified for the Paippalāda). Older HTML files say "for reference purposes only; copyright as for source file"	TEI: yes. HTML files (incl. the ŚB, MBh and Kuṛuntokai checked here): treat like eBL, keep local
SuttaCentral bilara-data	CC0 (verified)	yes
TITUS	no republication (verified)	local only
CAB	"CC", unspecified	verify before committing
Cologne csl-orig dictionaries	licence not checked	treat as per-word reference
archive.org PD items	PD	the scans themselves are binaries: gitignored, with a recipe

4.4 Searches still to run (the budget ran out)

1. The NLI catalogue for Hebrew translations of the Avesta and Gāthās, the Therīgāthā, the Mahābhārata episodes (Nala, Sāvitrī) and the Kaṭha.
2. The exact edition data of Shulman's *דקדוק האהבה*.
3. Whether Fridman 2014 includes ŚB 1.8.1, AB 7.13–18 and BAU 1.4.
4. Studies comparing Śunaḥśepa with Gen 22.
5. Studies comparing Yima's *vara* with Noah.
6. The open-access status of the Paippalāda volumes.
7. The status of an ORACC Achaemenid royal inscriptions project.
8. Brosius 1996 on the PFT birth rations.

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5. Sources consulted

Fetched (verified):

- https://raw.githubusercontent.com/VedaWebProject/vedaweb-data/main/README.md ; .../rigveda/TEI/vedaweb_corpus.tei ; .../rigveda/TEI/rv_book_10.tei

- https://raw.githubusercontent.com/cceh/c-salt_vedaweb_tei/master/README.md
- https://gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de/gretil.html ; .../gretil/1_sanskr/1_veda/2_bra/satapath/sb_01_u.htm ; .../gretil/1_sanskr/2_epic/mbh/mbh_03_u.htm ; .../gretil/4_drav/tamil/pm/pm110__u.htm ; .../gretil/corpustei/sa_paippalAdasaMhitA.xml ; .../gretil/1_sanskr/1_veda/1_sam/avs___u.htm
- https://titus.fkidg1.uni-frankfurt.de/texte/etcs/iran/airan/avesta/avest001.htm ; .../apers/apers001.htm ; .../ind/aind/ved/rv/ab/ab001.htm ; .../ind/aind/ved/yvw/sbm/sbm.htm ; .../iran/miran/mpers/bundahis/bunda.htm
- https://cab.geschkult.fu-berlin.de/exist/apps/cab/index.html ; .../pages/about/workprogress.html ; .../modules/get_corpus_plain.xql ; .../dictionaries/Bartholomae_Dictionary.html
- https://raw.githubusercontent.com/sanskrit-lexicon/csl-orig/master/v02/gra/gra.txt (and mw, pwg, ap90, bhs)
- https://raw.githubusercontent.com/suttacentral/bilara-data/published/README.md ; .../root/pli/ms/sutta/dn/dn27_root-pli-ms.json
- https://rigvedacommentary.alc.ucla.edu/
- https://isac.uchicago.edu/publications/persepolis-fortification-tablets
- https://www.livius.org/articles/place/behistun/behistun-3/
- https://www.sanskrit-linguistics.org/dcs/index.php
- archive.org advancedsearch and metadata API (items listed in §4.1)
- https://he.wikipedia.org/wiki/סנסקריט (list of Hebrew translations from Sanskrit)

Web searches (results used):

- https://www.carmelph.co.il/product/mizmorim_min_harig_veda/ ; https://www.text.org.il/index.php?book=0603122 ; https://www.ynet.co.il/articles/0,7340,L-3349708,00.html (Peter, Rigveda)
- https://www.carmelph.co.il/product/haofanishdot_vehabrahmanot/ ; https://7minim.wordpress.com/2014/05/16/uptrans/ (Fridman, Upaniṣads)
- https://pardes.co.il/?catnum=978-965-541-028-0&id=showbook ; https://federman.org/?p=66002 (Federman, Dhammapada)
- http://www.kerensheffi.com/selected-poems-from-the-therigata/ (Therīgāthā selections)
- https://www.e-vrit.co.il/Product/39005/ (Shulman, *דקדוק האהבה*)
- https://he.wikipedia.org/wiki/גאת'ות ; https://he.wikipedia.org/wiki/אווסטה (no Hebrew Gāthās found)
- https://iias.huji.ac.il/people/shaul-shaked